Residential Integration Act: proposal from the close advisers

To the decision maker | For referral to the analytical body | 17 October 2026

The problem and the political setting

A dictatorial government's close advisers regard geographically concentrated, racially homogeneous neighborhoods as a potential source of collective mobilization against the regime. They propose residential mixing as a means of reducing that perceived revolt risk. The government controls residential allocation and expects obedience. The advisers' belief about revolt risk is a premise of this proposal, not an established fact.

Residential context: Approximately 85% of residential locations are occupied, leaving about 15% vacant.

The proposed law

The imposed same-group minimum is 30% of occupied immediate-neighbor locations. Residents below that minimum must relocate to a vacant location; those meeting it remain in place. The rule governs action, regardless of residents' personal feelings.

This regulates a *minimum requirement*, not a maximum actual same-group share: a neighborhood with more than 30% same-group neighbors remains acceptable. The proposal does not require every neighborhood to contain exactly 30% of one group.

The intended goals

- **Ultimate political goal:** reduce the perceived risk of revolts and preserve regime stability.
- **Intermediate objective:** replace homogeneous residential clusters with broadly mixed neighborhoods.
- **Administrative objective:** secure compliance and allow residential arrangements to settle.

The advisers' rationale

Our reasoning has two links: requiring acceptance of mixed neighborhoods should produce residential mixing; that mixing should reduce the perceived risk of collective mobilization against the regime. With two groups of roughly equal size, we expect neighborhoods to become roughly balanced. We assume compliance and available vacancies will allow the city to settle.

Current assumptions

We invoke other governments' residential allocation practices as a provisional benchmark. Documented comparisons, their outcomes, and their local relevance remain to be established by the analytical body. Our current assumptions are:

- Requiring residents to accept mixed neighborhoods will produce an integrated city.
- More mixed neighborhoods will reduce the perceived risk of revolt.
- A uniform rule is appropriate despite local differences in housing availability.
- Relocation will bring neighborhoods into conformity with the rule and eventually stop.
- Administrative compliance will indicate progress toward the intended political goal.

The requested next step

Refer this proposal to the analytical body before deciding on adoption. We request an assessment of whether the proposed rule can produce the residential mixing on which the strategy depends, and what evidence supports the expected political benefit.

The assessment should identify weaknesses in this reasoning and the consequences of implementation. Local evidence on residents' choices, moving burdens, and the claimed relationship between mixing and revolt risk is not yet available.

Status of this page. A fictional advisers' memorandum, not an existing law or an endorsement. Its appeal to practices elsewhere is part of the hypothetical rationale, not a verified account of any government.

Representing the policy as a model

Dissect: describe what is happening

The proposed law requires residents to move if too few of their neighbors belong to their own group. A move changes the neighborhood both where someone leaves and where they arrive. It can therefore bring some residents into conformity with the rule while putting others below the minimum, prompting further moves. The evaluation tests whether these repeated moves produce mixed neighborhoods and eventually stop. The claimed effect on revolt risk lies outside this analysis.

Discretize: define the agents, arena, states, and rules

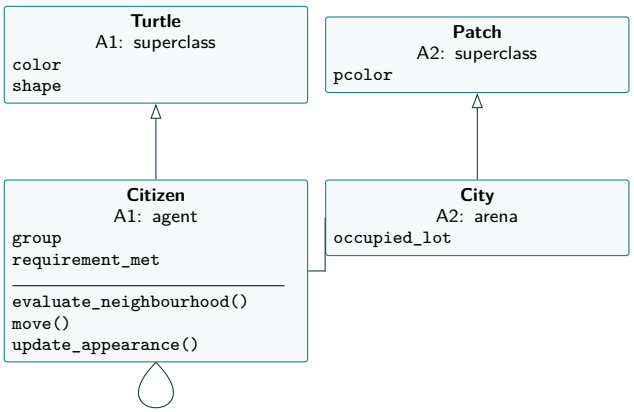
A1: citizens are agents with two owned states: `group` (0 or 1) and `requirement-met?` (true or false). Each citizen occupies one residential location and evaluates the group composition of nearby citizens.

A2: the city is the arena, represented by a bounded 51 by 51 grid without wrapping. Each location is vacant or occupied by one citizen, recorded as `occupied_lot?`. A neighborhood contains the up to eight surrounding locations; edge and corner locations have fewer neighbors. Only occupied neighbors enter the same-group share.

Initialization. Each location is independently occupied with probability 0.85. Each created citizen receives either group with equal probability. Realized occupancy and group proportions vary between runs. The initial arrangement is checked against the rule before relocation begins.

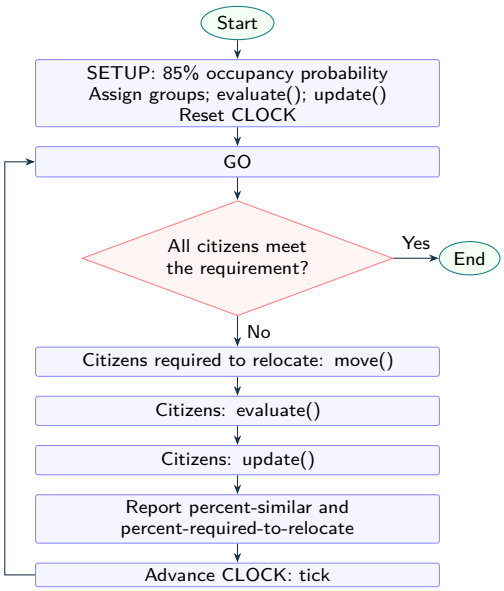
Methods and time. Residents below the minimum move to randomly selected vacancies. Destinations are not screened for suitability. After these moves, all neighborhoods are checked again. One model cycle records this sequence; it has no assigned calendar duration. Obedience is assumed; meeting the minimum does not signify personal approval.

Policy ontology



The diagram identifies residents, residential locations, and their relationships.

Policy flowchart



The cycle repeats until no further relocation is required. The experiment also stops unresolved runs at 1,000 cycles.

Scope of the comparison

Housing occupancy remains approximately 85% throughout the comparison. Only the imposed minimum changes between scenarios. The evaluation records the final residential pattern and whether relocation requirements have been resolved. It assumes obedience and available vacancies; it does not model housing costs, enforcement, or the disruption of moving.

Does the rule produce mixing that settles?

What the summary data show

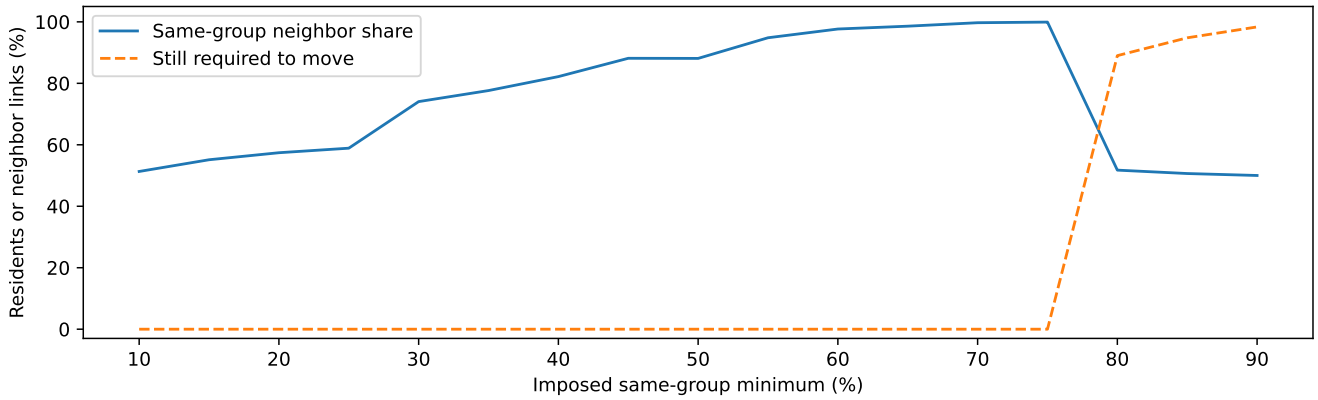
The evaluation compares 17 minimums, from 10% to 90% in five-point steps. Each scenario is simulated 30 times, giving **510 runs**. The imposed minimum does not determine the final neighborhood composition. A 30% minimum allows a resident to remain with 30%, 60%, or even 100% same-group neighbors.

How to read the results

Same-group neighbors describes the share of occupied neighbor links connecting people from the same group. With roughly equal group populations, a value near 50% is compatible with mixing. **Still required to move** counts residents below the imposed minimum at the endpoint. **Settled** means nobody remains below it; it does not mean that neighborhoods are mixed or that residents approve of the policy.

Imposed minimum	Same-group neighbors	Still required to move	Median final cycles	Settled runs
10%	51.3%	0%	2	30/30
25%	58.9%	0%	7	30/30
30%	74.1%	0%	12	30/30
70%	99.7%	0%	72	30/30
75%	99.9%	0%	180.5	30/30
80%	51.8%	89.0%	1,000 (cap)	0/30
90%	50.0%	98.4%	1,000 (cap)	0/30

Selected settings; percentages are means across 30 repetitions. Final cycles at the cap are observation limits, not times to settling.



Average outcomes across 30 simulations per setting. Lines connect the tested minimums.

Policy answer: replace the 30% proposal

Do not adopt the 30% minimum as a way to achieve residential mixing. All 30 runs settle, but same-group neighbor share averages 74.1%: roughly three out of four occupied neighbor links connect the same group. The rule sets a minimum, not a mixing target; residents can comply while living almost entirely among their own group.

Raising the minimum does not solve this problem. At 70–75%, similarity approaches 100% despite every run settling. At 80–90%, no run settles by the cap; mixed-looking endpoints accompany continuing relocation requirements.

Instead, replace the proposed 30% minimum with a 10% minimum. Among the tested settings, it provides the strongest combination of mixing and resolved relocation: all 30 runs settle and mean same-group similarity is 51.3%. It is the best-supported option among those tested. The spatial evidence also supports this recommendation.

Notebook 1: experiment outcomes. Open notebook

The notebook presents the summary table, combined mixing–relocation plot, and policy recommendation.

Does the rule reduce neighborhood separation?

Assess separation across the city

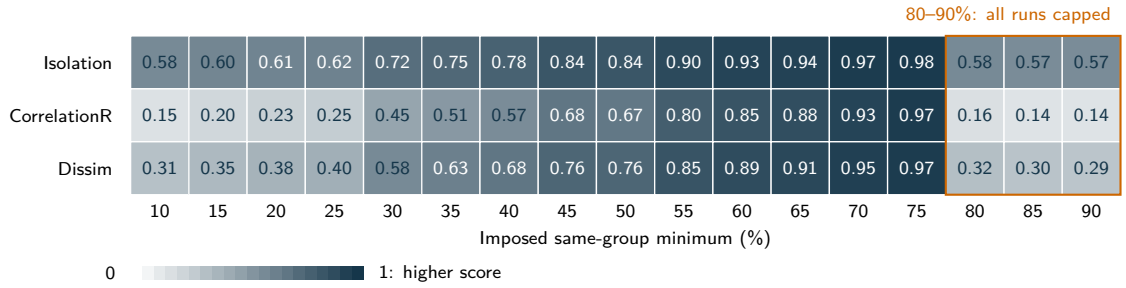
An end to relocation is not enough: the policy must also reduce separation between groups. Three established measures assess whether residents live mainly among their own group and whether group composition differs across neighborhoods. All scenarios are assessed at the same local scale, covering each residential location and its immediate surroundings.

What the three measures mean

Isolation measures how much residents live among their own group. A high score means little local exposure to the other group. However, a group that dominates the city naturally encounters itself often, even without residential separation.

CorrelationR adjusts isolation for the relative size of the group. It distinguishes separation from the greater same-group contact expected when one group is more numerous.

Dissim measures how unevenly the groups are distributed across neighborhoods. It is low when neighborhood group proportions are similar and high when they differ strongly. Higher scores indicate greater separation in the aspect measured. These scores support comparisons between policies; they are not percentages of residents classified as segregated.



Each cell is a mean across 30 repetitions, rounded to two decimals. Darker cells indicate higher values on a common 0–1 scale; the measures have different meanings and baselines. Orange outlines identify capped endpoints, not settled outcomes.

Results

What would the city look like if group membership played no part in where people lived? To make that comparison, we take each final city under the 30% rule and randomly redistribute its residents among the same occupied homes. The number of residents in each group and the vacant homes stay unchanged. We repeat this comparison many times, without applying the relocation rule again. This is the **random-mixing reference** in the table.

Random placement can still produce some same-group neighbors and small clusters by chance. The comparison asks whether the rule produces more separation than that. **It does: in every run, all three measures show greater separation than the random arrangements would ordinarily produce.** The 30% rule stops relocation but does not prevent segregation under this comparison.

Measure	Proposed 30%	Random-mixing reference	Recommended 10%
Isolation	0.723	0.567	0.578
CorrelationR	0.447	0.134	0.151
Dissim	0.576	0.293	0.307

The table shows average scores across 30 runs. The reference uses random arrangements of the cities produced by the 30% rule. Under both policy settings, no further moves were required by the end of every run.

Recommendation

Replace the proposed 30% minimum with 10%, the best-supported option among those tested. It produces less segregation on all three measures while bringing relocation to an end. The aim is to reduce segregation; some separation remains. The model supports this residential recommendation but does not establish that it will reduce revolt risk.

Evidence and methods. Schelling (1969); Wilensky's NetLogo Segregation model (1997), course adaptation by Prof. Jose Magallanes. Data: `policy-relocation-table.csv` and matching final-position exports; bounded grid, 30 repetitions. PySAL `segregation` 2.6.0 implements measures based on Massey and Denton (1988): methods documentation. Exact simulation reproduction requires the model and random seeds.

Notebook 2: spatial segregation. Open notebook